

This is slightly overstated by Stek, but he makes an essential point. The word “covenant” is absent from the Eden story because, ideally, the divine-human relationship should not need to be formalized because it should be a natural union of wills and purposes. This type of union between the divine and human wills characterizes Jesus’ relationship to the Father (see [John 5:19](#), [6:38](#), [7:16](#), [7:28](#), [8:29](#)), and it is the kind of divine-human union that was forfeited in Eden.

In this reading, the covenant is a rescue mechanism, or a means to an end. It formalizes the divine purpose into commitments, and it invites human partners to fulfill the divine will. As Jeremiah says, the new covenant will not be like the old because it will bring about a new creation, one in which the human will is made one with the divine in love and commitment ([Jer. 31:31-34](#)). In such a world, formal commitments and oaths become unnecessary.

The institution of covenant points to an Eden and new creation ideal, and it should be seen as a means to an end. That end is the union of God and humanity in love, will, and purpose. The apostle Paul calls this “the new humanity” ([Eph. 4:24](#)).

Reflection Question

How do you understand the word “covenant”? What does a covenant accomplish?

Session 21: Reflecting on God's Covenant

Key Takeaways

- Unlike the gods of Israel's neighbors who made promises contingent upon the people upholding the terms of their covenant, God obligates himself alone to sustain the covenant he made with all the Earth after the flood.
- The sign of the bow evokes images of peace (the retired war bow), reconciliation (a bridge between Heaven and Earth), and hope (the triumph of light over the darkness of the chaotic storm).

The Image of the "Bow in the Clouds" (Gen. 9:13, 14, 16)

"And is there not to every law of nature a background pointing to the mysteries of the Divine nature and will? The label of the rainbow is sufficiently legible. Shining upon a dark ground ... it represents the victory of the light of love over the fiery darkness of wrath. Originating from the effect of the sun upon a dark cloud, it typifies the willingness of the heavenly to penetrate the earthly. Stretched between heaven and earth, it is as a bond of peace between both, and, spanning the horizon, it points to the all-embracing universality of the Divine mercy."

Keil, C. F., and Delitzsch, F. (2006). [*Commentary on the Old Testament: Pentateuch \(Vol. 1\)*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 289-290.

Noah as an Archetypal Seed of the Woman

"While God is the main character of the narrative, Noah the righteous priest may yet be considered the literary 'hero' of the story, who both 'walks with' and 'brings rest' to God. Noah (נח), in fact, brings 'comfort' (נחם) both to humankind and to God. But further, not only because the narrative begins and ends with God's speech to Noah; and not only because the various wordplays on his name indicate Noah as a central character; but because the central question of the narrative concern salvation and worship: 'Who may ascend the mountain of Yahweh?' (Psalm 24:3) The flood narrative is really about Noah. This is to stress that the narrative is not really about the judgment of the world, but about how it was that Noah was saved from that judgment. ... The purpose of the story is not to show why God sent the flood, but to show why God saved Noah. The ark, not the flood, is the focus of the author's attention. ... As a priestly figure who is able to ascend the mountain of Yahweh, Noah stands as a new Adam, the primordial human who can dwell in the divine presence. As such he foreshadows the high priest in the tabernacle, who alone can enter the paradise of the holy of holies to purge the micro-cosmic tabernacle by making atonement."

Morales, Michael (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers. 190-192.



This session has no other notes

Reflection Question

Have you ever considered the horizontal, half-circle shape of a rainbow? It almost looks like a bow for shooting arrows. What does God's bow in the clouds represent?

Session 22: Noah's Ark and the Flood Debate

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors used cosmic hyperbole to emphasize the all-encompassing importance of the events described.
- Key vocabulary from the flood account is used at other points in the Bible to emphasize God's cosmic authority to hand creation over to its own self-destruction.

A Global Flood, a Local Flood, or Cosmic Collapse?

These two interpretive positions have received the most airtime in popular debate and culture. What they have in common is a desire to match the narrative details of the flood (especially Gen. 7:11-24) to a reconstructible historical flood that can be dated and located.

Both of these positions assume that the biblical author shares our modern cosmology and conception of the world as a "globe." Based on this assumption, the interpretive question becomes: Did the author have knowledge of the scope of the flood? This question results in multiple views.

- Global flood: The author knew (by divine inspiration) that the flood immersed the entire globe and depicted it as such.
- Local flood: The author didn't know about the scope and size of the globe and so depicted a localized flood as if it encompassed the entire globe.

Underneath this entire debate is an unexamined problem. The biblical authors did not share our modern cosmology, and the word "land" does not mean globe.

The language of 7:11-12 makes it clear that the author is working with an ancient world picture of a three-tiered cosmos.

Genesis 7:11-12 NASB*

¹¹ And in the six hundredth year of Noah's life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on that day all **the fountains of the great deep burst open**, and **the windows of the skies were opened**.¹² And there was rain upon the land for forty days and forty nights.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These phrases refer to the author's ancient conception of the waters above and below, which were separated on day two of Genesis. These cosmic waters exist and are held at bay only by Yahweh's covenant promise.

Genesis 1:6-8 NASB*

⁶ Then God said, "Let there be an dome in the midst of the waters, and let it separate **the waters** from the **waters.**" ⁷ God made the dome, and separated **the waters which were below the dome** from **the waters which were above the dome** and it was so. ⁸ God called the dome heavens/ skies. And there was evening and there was morning, a second day.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 148:1-6 NASB

- ¹ Praise the LORD! Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!
² Praise him, all his angels; praise him, all his hosts!
³ Praise him, sun and moon; praise him, all stars of light!
⁴ Praise him, **highest heavens, and the waters that are above the heavens!**
⁵ Let them praise the name of the LORD, for he commanded and they were created.
⁶ He has also **established them forever and ever; he has made a decree which will not pass away.**

Psalm 24:1-2 NASB*

- ¹ The **land** is the LORD's, and all it contains, the **world**, and those who dwell in it.
² For **he has founded it upon the seas, and established it upon the rivers.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 136:5-6 NASB

- ⁵ [Give thanks] to him who made the heavens with skill, for his lovingkindness is everlasting;
⁶ to **him who spread out the land above the waters**, for his lovingkindness is everlasting ...

Psalm 104:5 NASB*

He established the land upon its foundations, so that it will not totter forever and ever.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In light of the biblical authors' ancient cosmology, the depiction of the flood is neither global nor local. It is cosmic, or, more specifically, the flood is a cosmic collapse, a de-creation narrative. In other words, the depiction of the flood is an attempt to show its cosmic meaning and significance within the divine purpose.

Cosmic Hyperbole and the Flood Design Pattern in the Hebrew Bible

The author gives many clear signals that the flood has cosmic significance and affects the entire created realm. The following list is adapted from *The Lost World of the Flood* by Longman and Walton (2018, 48-49).

- God's perception of humanity in Genesis 6:5-13 includes all humanity, not just those in a local area.
- The flood is clearly portrayed as a reversal of the cosmic order that God established in Genesis 1 and then a re-creation similar to Genesis 1. For the analogy to work, the flood is a cosmic re-creation and not simply a local phenomenon.